

Samsung	Samsung
SCX-4720F	SCX-5315F
25.53	27.59
600x600	1200x1200
250	550
✓/✓	✓/✓
15000/5000	18750/6000
600x1200	600x600
4800x4800	4800x4800
24	24
Flatbed/CCD	Flatbed & Sheetfed/CCD
A4	A4
✓	✓
Scan to USB drive as BMP, TIFF or PDF	Scan to Folder
99	999
✗	✗
320	320
✓/✓	✓/✓
4.25	4.25
Optional	Optional
4.5	4.5
4.5	4.5
4.5	4.5
SmartThru 3 (with AnyPage OCR)	SmartThru 3 (with AnyPage OCR)
17/45.7x45x43.5	21.3/45.9x56x43.4
USB 2.0/Parallel	USB 2.0/Parallel
32/✓	8/✗
✓	✓
SPL	PCL6
Win/Lin	Win
Print TIFF, BMP, TXT, & PRN files from USB drive	✗
23.75	21.16
17	20
11.23/13.78	13.56/13.63
23.71/32.94	29.53/29.39
4	4.5
14/14.25	14.5/14.5
14.66	6.41
29.18	27.44
12	12
2.67	8
4.5	3.5
9.87	11.84
5.40	5.40
1/On site	1/On site
165	165
7.22	6.88
49995	64995
6999	5999
1.40	1.00
61.90	61.03

17 kg, and the Brother MFC-8220 was the lightest at 11.5 kg. The Brother MFC-8220 also had the smallest footprint of 45.1 x 33.5 cm, while the other two Brother MFDs were at 44.4 x 46.9 cm.

The SCX-4720F wins as far as build quality is concerned. It also looks much better than the Brother MFDs.

The Brother MFDs enjoy a 3-year on-site warranty, as opposed to Samsung's 1-year onsite warranty. But Samsung has a higher number of service centres across the country—165 to Brother's 105.

At Rs 49,995, Samsung SCX-4720F is the most expensive of the lot. Brother's MFC-8220, which has a Fax and a hand-set, costs Rs 26,150.

Performance

These being workgroup devices, we expected to see something good, but were disappointed on several counts. Take the warm-up times for example: the fastest time of 11 seconds, clocked by the Brother DCP 8040, was almost twice the fastest time in the earlier category.

However, the devices in this group are a lot more heavy-duty, and are not directly comparable to the previous group. The second-fastest time was logged by the Brother MFC 8220 at 12 seconds, while the 8440 and the Samsung SCX-4720F tied for third place at 17 seconds.

When printing our text documents, the SCX-4720F clocked 11.23 seconds and came first, marginally beating the Brother MFC-8440, which clocked 11.5 seconds. Third placed was the Brother DCP-8040 with a score of 14.28 seconds. Hence, if your usage will be mainly text oriented, we suggest you stick with the SCX 4720F. That said, we were surprised by these scores; we expected all devices to be much faster.

Getting to the quality tests, the Samsung printers outshone the rest easily with razor-sharp printouts in Best and Normal modes.

Coming a close second was the Brother MFC-8440, which kept up with the SCX-4720F for the most part, but lost out a bit on the 'white text on black background' tests. Hence, if you're planning on doing any kind of graphic-intensive printing, you should seriously consider the Samsung and the Brother MFC-8440.

In our scanner tests, the DCP-8040 at 13.14 seconds stood first, and the MFC-8440 was a close second, clocking 13.62 seconds. The DCP-8040 was also the best performer, providing one of the clearest scans we've seen so far.

In the OCR tests, the Brother MFC-8440 and DCP-8040 tied for the top spot with next-to-none errors in character recognition.

The Brother MFC-8220 performed poorly in this test. If you think you'll be scanning a lot of documents to text or PDF for editing or for direct printing with slight modifications, OCR becomes an important feature and you must look for an accurate OCR reader, as that would mean lesser time spent in editing and correcting the scanned document.

In our copier tests, the SCX-4720F was the fastest, clocking only 9.8 seconds to copy the document. Amazingly, it was also the winner in the quality department. The second here was the Brother DCP-8040, which took considerably longer than the Samsung printer, and was also much lower in terms of quality. But it tied with the slower MFC 8440, which took 11.78 seconds.



Samsung SCX-4720F

In terms of cost per page, the Brothers were the cheapest, costing only Rs 0.91 per printout, while the Samsung SCX 4720 is very expensive, at Rs 1.39 per page!

The 50 paise difference means that if you use the Samsung SCX 4720 for 3,000 documents per month, you would end up paying an additional Rs 1,200 every month!

Once again, given the heavy duty usage, the warranty offered becomes important. Brother provides a 3-year carry-in warranty with 105 authorised service centres, while strangely, Samsung provides only a 1-year on-site warranty. Samsung, though, has more service centres.

Conclusion

The Digit 'Best Buy Gold' award went to the Brother MFC-8440. It is a top-notch performer, and only the Samsung SCX-4720F performs better. But since the MFC-8440 boasts of a 20,000-page monthly duty cycle, and is also priced considerably lower—Rs 35,000—than the Samsung SCX-4720F, it earned the Gold award. Despite its high price, though, the Samsung SCX-4720F, clinched the Digit 'Best Buy Silver' award. ■

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